forces many steps back, besides consuming a lot of time and energy of those in higher echelons of the government, including the Parliament and the state assemblies. Directions were issued that any allegations of such violations were to be speedily investigated in a fair and transparent manner. Each infringement or mistake by our men in uniform would give the Pakistani propaganda machinery the leverage to justify their calling us an 'occupation army'. The media loves to play up such stories, which furthers the cause of the insurgents and helps to raise their morale. I endeavoured to make this fundamental issue understood by every soldier. As a result, the local population became appreciative of the army's efforts and change in attitude and began to readily share information about terrorists, leading to successful operations. Growing signs of normalcy in the state are reflective of this change.

At the same time, action needs to be taken to provide solace, financial aid and other help to the aggrieved families by the government and the army. To win over the hearts and minds of the people, Operation Sadbhavana has been going on for a long time. This operation comprises a number of socioeconomic and civic action programmes undertaken by the army in the remote and underdeveloped areas to improve the lot of the people. These projects comprise the building of roads, bridges, model villages, goodwill schools, handicrafts development centres, and water and electricity supply schemes. These projects are executed by the army and have the formal support and funding of the ministries of defence and home affairs. They have been a huge success both in J&K and in the northeast. The armed forces have also been praised by the citizens for responding instantaneously whenever natural calamities like earthquakes, floods or heavy snowfall have struck these areas. Also, efforts were continuously made to encourage surrenders by the local misguided youth – they were given an opportunity to rejoin the national mainstream. This was a step in the right direction. Giving these surrendered terrorists some vocational training along with a viable financial package to help them rehabilitate themselves was definitely cheaper than a long-drawn-out counterterrorist campaign.